



THE STATE OF MENSTRUAL EQUITY IN AFRICA

2026 – 1st Edition

Prepared By
Jennifer Akong



Foreword

This report is more than a collection of data. It is a call to action.



Every generation is presented with defining challenges that test its commitment to equality, dignity, and justice. For ours, one of those challenges is ensuring that no woman or girl is disadvantaged simply because she menstruates.

Menstruation is a natural part of life. Yet for millions of women and girls across Africa, it remains surrounded by stigma, silence, and systemic barriers. Too many girls continue to miss school because they cannot afford menstrual products. Too many women navigate workplaces and public spaces without adequate facilities. Too many communities still lack access to accurate menstrual health education, safe sanitation, and quality healthcare.

These realities are not inevitable. They are the result of inequalities that can and must be addressed.

The State of Menstrual Equity in Africa 2026 was developed to shine a light on these realities while also celebrating the remarkable progress being made across the continent. It brings together evidence, research, and lived experiences to provide a comprehensive picture of menstrual health in Africa today. More importantly, it reminds us that behind every statistic is a girl with dreams, a young woman pursuing an education, a mother supporting her family, or a community striving for a better future.

At **A Thousand Women Africa**, we believe that menstrual equity is fundamental to achieving gender equality, improving educational outcomes, advancing public health, and unlocking economic opportunity. When girls can manage their periods safely and with dignity, they are more likely to remain in school, participate confidently in society, and realise their full potential. Investing in menstrual health is therefore an investment in Africa's future.

Through initiatives such as our **End Period Poverty Project**, we have witnessed both the challenges faced by women and girls and the extraordinary resilience they demonstrate every day. We have learned that sustainable change requires more than providing menstrual products. It requires education, advocacy, supportive policies, improved infrastructure, community engagement, and innovations that make menstrual care accessible, affordable, and environmentally sustainable.

Executive Summary

Menstrual health is increasingly recognised as a critical public health, education, and gender equality issue. Yet across Africa, millions of women and girls continue to face barriers that prevent them from managing menstruation safely, confidently, and with dignity. These barriers extend beyond the affordability of menstrual products to include inadequate water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) facilities, limited menstrual health education, restricted access to healthcare, persistent social stigma, and policy gaps.

The State of Menstrual Equity in Africa 2026 provides an evidence-based overview of the current menstrual health landscape across the continent. Drawing on research from international organisations, peer-reviewed literature, and African case studies, the report examines how systemic inequalities shape menstrual experiences and why addressing them is essential for achieving sustainable development.

The report is organised into three chapters:

1	2	3
Chapter One Introduces the concept of menstrual equity and explains why menstruation should be recognised as a matter of health, education, dignity, human rights, and gender equality. It establishes the broader context of menstrual inequity in Africa and outlines the purpose of the report.	Chapter Two Explores the evolution of menstrual health, tracing its journey from a largely overlooked private issue to an internationally recognised development priority. It examines the shift from Menstrual Hygiene Management (MHM) to menstrual equity, highlighting the growing emphasis on dignity, equality, policy reform, and human rights.	Chapter Three Presents the current state of menstrual equity across Africa through available evidence, statistics, and real-world examples. It examines the impact of period poverty, inadequate sanitation infrastructure, educational barriers, and unequal access to menstrual health resources. The chapter also highlights emerging African-led solutions, including the work of A Thousand Women Africa through its End Period Poverty Project and Luwa.

The report finds that menstrual inequity remains a significant but solvable challenge. While encouraging progress has been made through advocacy, research, policy development, and community-led initiatives, millions of women and girls continue to experience barriers that affect their health, education, economic participation, and overall well-being.

Achieving menstrual equity will require sustained collaboration between governments, educators, healthcare professionals, civil society organisations, the private sector, and communities. It also requires greater investment in data, infrastructure, education, affordable menstrual products, and locally led innovations that reflect Africa's diverse contexts.

Ultimately, menstrual equity is not simply about managing periods. It is about ensuring that every woman and girl can participate fully in society without barriers created by a natural biological process.

By placing African voices, evidence, and solutions at the centre of the conversation, this report aims to inform policy, strengthen advocacy, and contribute to a future where menstruation is no longer a source of inequality but a recognised component of health, dignity, and opportunity.

Table of Contents

Foreword	1
Executive Summary	2
<u>Chapter One: Introduction</u>	<u>6</u>
1.1 A Monthly Reality: The Human Story Behind Menstrual Inequity	
1.2 Understanding Menstrual Equity: Beyond the Period Product	
1.3 Menstrual Health as a Human Rights and Development Issue	
1.4 The African Context: Why Menstrual Equity Matters	
1.5 Menstrual Equity and the Sustainable Development Goals	
1.6 Purpose of This Report	
1.7 Conclusion	
References	14
<u>Chapter Two: The Evolution of Menstrual Health and Equity</u>	<u>15</u>
2.1 Introduction: How a Private Experience Became a Global Development Issue	
2.2 The Historical Silence Around Menstruation	
2.3 The Emergence of Menstrual Health as a Development Issue	
2.4 The Global Movement for Menstrual Health	
2.5 From Menstrual Hygiene Management to Menstrual Equity	
2.5.1 Why the Definition Expanded	
2.5.2 The Limitations of Product-Only Approaches	
2.5.3 The Role of Dignity and Equality	
2.6 Menstrual Equity as a Human Rights Issue	
2.7 The Role of Advocacy and Policy Change	
2.8 The Future of Menstrual Equity	

<u>References</u>	<u>30</u>
<u>Chapter Three: The State of Menstrual Equity in Africa</u>	<u>31</u>
3.1 Introduction: The African Menstrual Reality	
3.2 Menstrual Equity in Numbers: Understanding the Scale	
3.3 Period Poverty: When Menstruation Becomes Unaffordable	
3.4 The Education Cost of Menstrual Inequity	
3.5 Beyond the Numbers: The Human Experience	
3.6 The Nigerian Context: A Closer Look	
3.7 African-Led Solutions: The Movement Towards Change	
A Thousand Women Africa: Empowering Girls Through Menstrual Equity	
Luwa: Innovation for Sustainable Menstrual Solutions	
3.8 The Way Forward	
3.9 Conclusion: Beyond the Statistics	
3.10 Key Findings at a Glance	
<u>References</u>	<u>42</u>
<u>About A Thousand Women Africa</u>	<u>43</u>

Chapter One: Introduction

"Menstruation is not a choice, yet for millions of African women and girls, managing it with dignity remains out of reach."



1.1 A Monthly Reality: The Human Story Behind Menstrual Inequity

Imagine being a 13-year-old girl experiencing your first menstrual period.

You are sitting in a classroom, trying to understand a change happening in your body. Nobody explained what menstruation was or what to expect. You feel confused, anxious, and afraid to ask questions because conversations about periods are considered uncomfortable or inappropriate.

When your period arrives, you realise you do not have enough sanitary products to last the month. The toilets at your school do not have running water, soap, or enough privacy. You worry about staining your uniform, being laughed at by classmates, or being labelled because of something completely natural.

By midday, you decide to leave school.

For millions of girls across Africa, this experience is not a hypothetical situation. It represents a reality repeated every month.

Menstruation is a natural biological process experienced by approximately 1.8 billion people worldwide, yet millions continue to experience menstruation within environments that fail to provide the resources, information, healthcare, and support required to manage it safely and with dignity (UNICEF, 2021; World Health Organization [WHO], 2022).

The challenge is not menstruation itself.

The challenge is the inequality surrounding menstruation.

A girl's ability to manage her menstrual cycle should not determine whether she attends school, participates confidently in society, protects her health, or reaches her full potential. However, across many African countries, menstrual experiences are shaped by interconnected barriers including poverty, inadequate sanitation infrastructure, limited access to healthcare, insufficient education, cultural stigma, and weak policy implementation (Hennegan et al., 2021).

This reality has brought menstrual health into global conversations around gender equality, education, public health, and human rights. Increasingly, researchers, governments, and development organisations recognise that menstrual health is not simply a private issue affecting individuals, it is a societal issue influenced by systems, institutions, and policies.

This is the foundation of **menstrual equity**.

1.2 Understanding Menstrual Equity: Beyond the Period Product

For many years, discussions about menstruation focused primarily on menstrual hygiene management (MHM). This approach highlighted the importance of access to sanitary products, cleanliness, and safe sanitation facilities.

While these areas remain essential, research has demonstrated that menstrual challenges are much broader than the absence of menstrual products.

A girl may receive sanitary pads but still experience menstrual inequity if:

she does not understand the changes happening in her body;

she fears shame or discrimination;

her school lacks private sanitation facilities;

she cannot access healthcare for painful or irregular periods;

cultural beliefs prevent her from participating fully in daily life.

Therefore, menstrual equity requires a more comprehensive understanding.

Menstrual equity refers to the condition where all women and girls have equal access to the resources, knowledge, healthcare, infrastructure, and social support needed to manage menstruation safely, confidently, and with dignity (Hennegan et al., 2021; WHO, 2022).

It recognises menstruation as not only a health issue but also an issue connected to:

Education

Economic Participation

Gender Equality

Human Rights

Social Inclusion

The movement towards menstrual equity represents a shift from asking:

"How can girls better manage their periods?"

to asking:

"How can societies remove the barriers that prevent girls and women from managing their periods with dignity?"

This distinction is important because menstrual inequity is rarely caused by individual behaviour. It is created and reinforced by wider social and economic systems.

1.3 Menstrual Health as a Human Rights and Development Issue

Menstruation has historically been treated as a private matter, often surrounded by silence and shame.

However, international organisations increasingly recognise that the ability to manage menstruation safely is closely linked to fundamental human rights.

Menstrual health connects directly with the rights to:



Health



Education



Water and Sanitation



Equality



Dignity



Participation in Society

The World Health Organization defines menstrual health as a state of complete physical, mental, and social well-being related to the menstrual cycle, rather than simply the absence of disease or discomfort (WHO, 2022).

This definition is significant because it acknowledges that menstrual experiences are shaped by more than biology. A person's menstrual health is influenced by whether they have access to accurate information, supportive environments, appropriate healthcare, and the ability to participate in everyday activities without shame or restriction.

Across Africa, menstrual health challenges are closely connected to broader development issues.

A girl who misses school because she cannot access menstrual products is experiencing an education inequality.

A woman who misses work because her workplace lacks appropriate facilities is experiencing an economic inequality.

A young person who cannot seek medical support for severe menstrual pain because of stigma is experiencing a healthcare inequality.

Menstrual equity therefore represents a broader commitment to creating societies where women and girls are able to participate fully and equally.

1.4 The African Context: Why Menstrual Equity Matters

Africa has one of the youngest populations in the world, with millions of girls entering adolescence every year.

Supporting these girls through puberty and ensuring they can manage menstruation safely is essential for achieving long-term social and economic development.

However, menstrual experiences across the continent remain deeply unequal.

For many girls and women, menstruation occurs within environments affected by:



Economic Inequality

Menstrual products are often treated as optional expenses rather than essential health products. For families facing financial hardship, purchasing sanitary products may compete with other necessities such as food, housing, transportation, and school fees.

This creates a situation known as **period poverty**.

Period poverty refers not only to the inability to afford menstrual products but also to the inability to access the information, sanitation facilities, and healthcare needed to manage menstruation effectively (Hennegan et al., 2021).



Limited Access to Water, Sanitation and Hygiene Facilities

Safe menstrual management requires more than products. Girls need access to:

- clean water;
- private toilets;
- soap;
- safe disposal systems;
- changing spaces.

However, many schools and communities across Africa continue to face significant WASH (Water, Sanitation and Hygiene) challenges.

When girls cannot manage their periods privately and safely, menstruation can become a source of anxiety and exclusion rather than a normal part of life (UNICEF, 2021).



Menstrual Stigma and Harmful Social Norms

In many communities, menstruation remains surrounded by myths and misconceptions.

Some girls grow up believing that menstruation is something shameful or that it should not be discussed openly. These beliefs can affect confidence, education, healthcare-seeking behaviour, and relationships.

Research shows that stigma can be as damaging as the absence of physical resources because it shapes how girls understand themselves and how society responds to them (Sommer et al., 2015).



Limited Menstrual Health Education

Many girls experience their first period without adequate preparation.

Without accurate information, menstruation can become a frightening experience associated with confusion and embarrassment.

Comprehensive menstrual education allows girls to understand their bodies, recognise healthy and unhealthy menstrual experiences, and seek support when necessary.

Education must also include boys, men, teachers, families, and communities because menstrual equity cannot be achieved when menstruation remains a topic surrounded by silence.

1.5 Menstrual Equity and the Sustainable Development Goals

Menstrual equity is closely connected to global development priorities.

The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) recognise that improving the lives of women and girls requires addressing interconnected social challenges. Menstrual health contributes directly to:



SDG 3: Good Health and Well-being

Through improved reproductive health awareness and access to healthcare.



SDG 4: Quality Education

Through reducing barriers that prevent girls from fully participating in school.



SDG 5: Gender Equality

Through challenging discrimination and promoting dignity.



SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation

Through improved access to safe sanitation facilities.



SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities

Through addressing disparities affecting vulnerable communities.

(United Nations, 2015)

Investing in menstrual equity is therefore not simply an investment in menstrual products. It is an investment in education, health, equality, and economic opportunity.

1.6 Purpose of This Report

The State of Menstrual Equity in Africa 2026 examines the current realities, challenges, progress, and opportunities surrounding menstrual health across the continent.

This report aims to:

- 1 Examine the major barriers affecting menstrual equity in Africa.**
- 2 Analyse how poverty, infrastructure, culture, policy, and healthcare systems influence menstrual experiences.**
- 3 Highlight successful interventions and innovations across African countries.**
- 4 Explore the role of governments, NGOs, communities, and private organisations in advancing menstrual justice.**
- 5 Provide recommendations for achieving sustainable menstrual equity.**

The report draws upon peer-reviewed research, international development reports, government publications, and case studies from across Africa to provide an evidence-based understanding of menstrual health challenges and solutions.

1.7 Conclusion

Menstruation is a biological reality, but menstrual inequity is a social and systemic challenge.

No girl should miss school because she cannot afford menstrual products. No woman should experience shame because of a natural bodily function. No community should lack the knowledge, resources, or infrastructure required to support menstrual health.

Achieving menstrual equity in Africa requires more than addressing periods. It requires addressing the systems surrounding them.

The journey towards menstrual justice is ultimately a journey towards dignity, equality, and opportunity for every woman and girl.

References

Hennegan, J., Winkler, I. T., Bobel, C., Keiser, D., Hampton, J., Larsson, G., Chandra-Mouli, V., Plesons, M., & Mahon, T. (2021). *Menstrual health: A definition for policy, practice, and research*. Sexual and Reproductive Health Matters, 29(1), 1911618.

Sommer, M., Schmitt, M. L., Clatworthy, D., Bramucci, G., Wheeler, E., & Ratnayake, R. (2021). *What is the scope for addressing menstrual hygiene management in complex humanitarian emergencies?* International Journal of Public Health.

UNESCO. (2014). *Puberty education and menstrual hygiene management*.

UNICEF. (2021). *Guidance on Menstrual Health and Hygiene*.

United Nations. (2015). *Transforming Our World: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development*.

UN Women. (2022). *The impact of COVID-19 on women and girls*.

UN Women. (2023). *Menstrual Health and Gender Equality*.

WaterAid. (2022). *Menstrual Health Matters*.

World Health Organization. (2022). *Statement on Menstrual Health and Hygiene*.

Chapter Two: The Evolution of Menstrual Health and Equity

From Silence and Stigma to Global Recognition and Action



2.1 Introduction: How a Private Experience Became a Global Development Issue

For generations, menstruation has been experienced by billions of women and girls across the world, yet conversations about it have often remained hidden behind silence, shame, and misunderstanding.

Although menstruation is a natural biological process, societies have historically treated it as a private matter rather than an issue connected to public health, education, equality, and human rights. This silence has influenced how women and girls experience their periods, shaping access to information, healthcare, sanitation, and social support.

For many years, menstruation was rarely discussed in policy spaces, schools, or healthcare systems. The absence of conversation contributed to a lack of research, limited investment, and insufficient attention to the challenges faced by millions of menstruating people worldwide.

However, over the past few decades, the global understanding of menstruation has changed significantly. Researchers, activists, governments, and international organisations have increasingly recognised that menstrual experiences are shaped by wider social systems.

Economic Inequality

A girl missing school because she lacks menstrual products is not experiencing a personal failure. She is experiencing the effects of economic inequality.

Workplace and Policy Gap

A woman unable to manage her period at work because facilities are unavailable is not facing an individual inconvenience. She is experiencing a workplace and policy gap.

Health Systems Failure

A young person unable to seek healthcare for severe menstrual pain because of stigma is not simply lacking information. They are experiencing a failure of health systems and social support.

This growing recognition has transformed menstruation from a private experience into a global development priority.

The journey towards menstrual equity has been shaped by decades of advocacy, research, and community action. Understanding this history is essential to understanding where menstrual equity stands today and where future efforts must focus.

2.2 The Historical Silence Around Menstruation

Throughout history, menstruation has been influenced by cultural beliefs, social traditions, and gender expectations. Across different societies, menstrual blood has been associated with ideas of purity, impurity, secrecy, and shame.

While cultural attitudes towards menstruation vary widely, one common pattern exists across many communities: menstruation has often been treated as something that should remain hidden.

This silence has affected generations of women and girls.

Many girls enter puberty without adequate knowledge about menstruation, leaving them unprepared for their first period. Without accurate information, normal bodily changes can become sources of fear and confusion.

Research has shown that negative menstrual attitudes can influence how girls perceive their bodies, whether they seek healthcare support, and how confidently they participate in everyday activities (Sommer et al., 2015).

The consequences of menstrual stigma are significant because stigma does not exist separately from other inequalities. It often interacts with poverty, gender discrimination, limited education, and inadequate healthcare systems.

For example, a girl from a low-income household may face multiple barriers at the same time:

Affordability

She may not be able to afford menstrual products.

Information

She may lack accurate information about menstruation.

Sanitation

She may attend a school without appropriate sanitation facilities.

Open Discussion

She may feel unable to discuss menstrual concerns openly.

These overlapping challenges demonstrate why menstrual equity requires a systems-based approach.

2.3 The Emergence of Menstrual Health as a Development Issue

For much of the twentieth century, menstruation received limited attention within global health and development discussions. Although reproductive health had increasingly become a recognised area of concern, menstrual health was often overlooked.

This began to change as researchers and organisations identified links between menstruation and girls' education.

Across many low- and middle-income countries, evidence showed that girls faced challenges attending school during menstruation due to:

- lack of affordable menstrual products;
- inadequate school toilets;
- limited privacy;
- fear of embarrassment;
- insufficient menstrual education.

This led to increased attention towards Menstrual Hygiene Management (MHM), particularly within education and WASH programmes.

The focus of early menstrual health interventions was largely practical:

Menstrual Materials

providing menstrual materials;

Sanitation

improving sanitation facilities;

Hygiene Practices

teaching hygiene practices;

Puberty Support

supporting girls during puberty.

These interventions were important because they addressed immediate barriers faced by many girls. However, researchers and advocates soon recognised that menstrual challenges extended beyond hygiene.

A girl may have access to menstrual products but still experience exclusion because of stigma.

A school may provide toilets but fail to provide accurate menstrual education.

A country may introduce policies but fail to ensure implementation.

These realities highlighted the need for a broader understanding of menstrual health.

2.4 The Global Movement for Menstrual Health

The recognition of menstrual health as a development issue has grown through decades of research, advocacy, and policy change.

Before 2000: Menstruation as a Hidden Issue

Before the early 2000s, menstruation received limited attention in international development discussions.

Most conversations focused on reproductive health more broadly, while the everyday experiences of menstruating women and girls remained largely invisible.

There was limited research on:

menstrual experiences among adolescents;

barriers to menstrual product access;

school environments;

social stigma.

As a result, many menstrual challenges remained undocumented and unaddressed.

2000–2010: The Connection Between Menstruation, Education, and WASH

The early 2000s marked an important shift.

Researchers began examining how menstruation affected girls' education, particularly in communities where schools lacked adequate sanitation facilities.

The connection between menstruation and WASH became increasingly recognised.

Attention focused on the importance of:



Private School Toilets



Clean Water



Hygiene Facilities



Safe Disposal Systems

During this period, many NGOs began implementing school-based menstrual health programmes across Africa and other regions.

These programmes demonstrated that supporting girls during menstruation could improve confidence, participation, and school experiences.

2010–2020: Menstrual Hygiene Enters Global Development Agendas

Between 2010 and 2020, menstrual health gained significant global recognition.

Research expanded, advocacy movements grew, and more organisations began addressing menstruation as part of broader gender equality and development work.

Important developments included:

- 01**
increased academic research on menstrual health;
- 02**
global awareness campaigns;
- 03**
youth-led advocacy movements;
- 04**
government discussions on menstrual product taxation;
- 05**
integration of menstrual health into education and WASH programmes.

International organisations including UNICEF, UNESCO, WHO, UN Women, and WaterAid contributed to increasing awareness and developing guidance for governments and practitioners.

The conversation began shifting from:

"Girls need menstrual products."

to:

"Girls need environments that allow them to manage menstruation safely and with dignity."

2020–Present: The Rise of Menstrual Equity and Justice

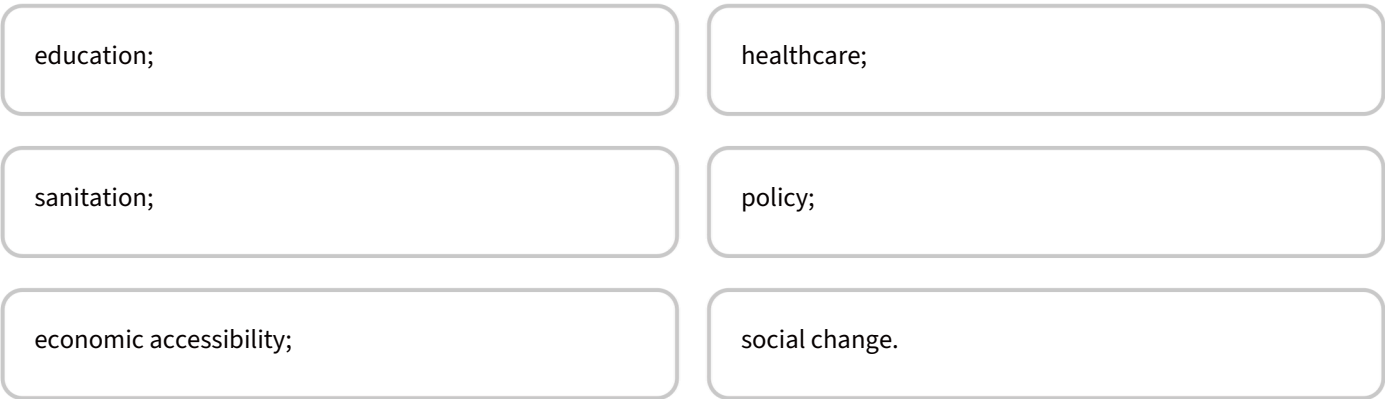
In recent years, the menstrual health movement has continued to evolve.

The focus has expanded from menstrual hygiene management towards broader concepts of:



This shift recognises that menstrual inequality is created by multiple interconnected systems.

A sustainable solution requires more than distributing products. It requires investment in:



The COVID-19 pandemic further highlighted these inequalities. Disruptions to supply chains, rising costs, and increased economic pressure affected access to menstrual products and services, particularly among vulnerable communities (UN Women, 2022).

2.5 From Menstrual Hygiene Management to Menstrual Equity

The global conversation around menstruation has evolved significantly over the past two decades.

Early efforts focused primarily on Menstrual Hygiene Management (MHM), an approach that highlighted the importance of access to menstrual products, clean water, sanitation facilities, and hygiene practices.

This approach was an important first step. For many girls and women, the immediate challenge was the inability to access safe and appropriate menstrual materials. Addressing these barriers helped bring attention to the realities faced by millions of menstruating people, particularly those living in low-income communities.

However, as research and advocacy expanded, it became clear that menstrual challenges could not be solved through products alone.

A menstrual product, whether disposable or reusable, is only one part of the menstrual experience.

A girl may receive free sanitary pads but still miss school because:

she does not understand menstruation or how to manage her cycle;

she experiences shame or fear of being judged;

her school lacks private toilets and water facilities;

she cannot access healthcare for severe menstrual pain;

cultural beliefs restrict her participation during menstruation.

This understanding led to a broader approach: menstrual health and ultimately menstrual equity.

Menstrual equity recognises that the ability to manage menstruation is influenced by wider social, economic, and structural factors. It considers not only whether someone has a menstrual product, but whether they have the knowledge, support, healthcare, infrastructure, and social acceptance needed to experience menstruation safely and with dignity (Hennegan et al., 2021).

2.5.1 Why the Definition Expanded

The expansion from menstrual hygiene management to menstrual equity reflects a deeper understanding of the realities faced by women and girls.

Early menstrual health programmes often measured success through practical outcomes, such as:

the number of girls receiving menstrual products;

the availability of sanitation facilities;

improvements in hygiene practices.

While these indicators remain important, they do not fully capture the complexity of menstrual experiences.

Researchers found that menstrual challenges were influenced by multiple interconnected factors, including:

Poverty

Gender Inequality

Healthcare Access

Education

Cultural Beliefs

Government Policies

Social Attitudes

This led to a recognition that menstruation is not only a biological process requiring hygiene solutions. It is also a social experience shaped by the environment in which a person lives.

The expanded definition of menstrual equity therefore asks broader questions:

- ☐ Can girls attend school confidently during menstruation?
- ☐ Can women access healthcare when they experience menstrual problems?
- ☐ Can people discuss menstruation without shame?
- ☐ Are menstrual products affordable and available to everyone who needs them?
- ☐ Do policies protect menstrual dignity?

These questions move the conversation from managing periods to transforming the conditions surrounding periods.

2.7 The Role of Advocacy and Policy Change

The growth of the menstrual equity movement has been driven by the efforts of activists, researchers, young people, community organisations, and international institutions.

Advocacy has played a significant role in changing how menstruation is discussed and prioritised.

For decades, menstrual issues remained absent from many public policies. However, increasing awareness has encouraged governments to introduce new approaches, including:

- 1 removing taxes on menstrual products;
- 2 providing free or subsidised menstrual products;
- 3 integrating menstrual health education into schools;
- 4 improving WASH facilities;
- 5 developing national menstrual health strategies.

Across Africa, advocacy movements have demonstrated the power of community-led solutions.

Young activists, women-led organisations, and local NGOs have challenged menstrual stigma by creating spaces where menstruation can be discussed openly. These movements have helped shift the narrative from shame to empowerment.

Civil society organisations have also played an important role by:

distributing menstrual products;

conducting education programmes;

training teachers and community leaders;

collecting research data;

influencing government policy.

However, advocacy alone cannot achieve menstrual equity. Sustainable change requires collaboration between governments, communities, researchers, development organisations, and the private sector.

Policy commitments must also be supported by funding, implementation strategies, and accountability systems.

A policy that exists only on paper cannot transform lives.

African Leadership in Menstrual Equity

Africa is not only a region experiencing menstrual challenges. It is also a continent producing innovative solutions.

Across African communities, organisations and advocates are developing approaches that combine education, entrepreneurship, healthcare, and social change.



Education



Entrepreneurship



Healthcare



Social Change

The future of menstrual equity must centre African voices, experiences, and solutions.

The goal is not simply to make menstruation easier to manage.

The goal is to create societies where menstruation is understood, supported, and respected as a normal part of human life.

2.8 The Future of Menstrual Equity

The future of menstrual equity requires moving from short-term interventions towards sustainable, long-term solutions.

Several areas will shape the next generation of menstrual health efforts.

Sustainable Menstrual Solutions

Environmental concerns are increasingly influencing conversations about menstrual products.

The growth of reusable and biodegradable menstrual products provides opportunities to address both affordability and environmental sustainability.

However, sustainable solutions must remain accessible and culturally appropriate. A product is only effective if individuals can comfortably and safely use it within their communities.

Accessible

Solutions must be readily available and affordable for all individuals, regardless of socioeconomic status or geographical location.

Culturally Appropriate

Products and practices must align with local customs, beliefs, and preferences to ensure comfortable and dignified use within communities.

Local Manufacturing and Economic Empowerment

Developing local menstrual product manufacturing can improve access while creating economic opportunities.

African-led production of menstrual products has the potential to:

reduce dependence on imported products;

create jobs;

strengthen local economies;

improve affordability.

Digital Education and Innovation

Technology offers new opportunities for menstrual education and support. Digital

platforms can provide:

- accurate menstrual information; cycle
- tracking tools;
- healthcare guidance;
- safe spaces for discussion.

□ However, digital solutions must consider unequal access to technology, particularly among rural and low-income communities.

Stronger Policy Commitment

Future progress will depend on stronger government leadership.

Effective menstrual equity policies require:

Dedicated funding matters because menstrual equity cannot depend on short-term projects or uncertain donor support. Stable budgets allow governments to procure products, train staff, expand services, and maintain programs over time. This also makes it possible to reach underserved communities consistently rather than only during isolated campaigns.

Measurable targets are important because they turn broad commitments into accountability. Clear goals make it easier to track whether policies are actually improving access, reducing stigma, and reaching people who have been excluded. They also help decision-makers identify what is working, where gaps remain, and where additional support is needed.

Collaboration across sectors entails coordination between health, education, finance, sanitation, and social protection systems. Menstrual equity is not just a health issue; it affects school attendance, workplace participation, infrastructure, and public awareness. When sectors work together, policies are more likely to be practical, well-resourced, and effective in everyday life.

Community involvement ensures that policies reflect the real experiences and priorities of the people they are meant to serve. Local voices can highlight barriers that may be missed by national planners, such as cultural concerns, affordability, privacy, and access to facilities. Including communities in design, implementation, and evaluation also builds trust and improves long-term adoption.

Key Insights

Evolution of Menstrual Equity

1

Menstrual health has moved from silence to recognition.

What was once considered a private issue is now recognised as a global development priority.

2

Products are necessary but not sufficient.

Menstrual equity requires education, healthcare, sanitation, and social support.

3

Menstrual health is connected to human rights.

Dignity, equality, health, and education are all affected by menstrual experiences.

4

Advocacy creates change.

Community movements and policy action have transformed the way menstruation is understood.

5

The future requires sustainable and inclusive solutions.

Long-term progress depends on innovation, investment, and African-led approaches.

References

- Hennegan, J., Winkler, I.T., Bobel, C., Keiser, D., Hampton, J., Larsson, G., Chandra-Mouli, V., Plesons, M., & Mahon, T. (2021). Menstrual health: *A definition for policy, practice, and research*. *Sexual and Reproductive Health Matters*, 29(1), 1911618.
- Sommer, M., Schmitt, M. L., Clatworthy, D., Bramucci, G., Wheeler, E., & Ratnayake, R. (2015). *What is the scope for addressing menstrual hygiene management in complex humanitarian emergencies?* *Waterlines*, 34(3), 245–264.
- UNESCO. (2014). *Puberty Education and Menstrual Hygiene Management*.
- UNICEF. (2021). *Guidance on Menstrual Health and Hygiene*.
- UN Women. (2022). *The Impact of COVID-19 on Women and Girls*.
- United Nations. (2015). *Transforming Our World: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development*.
- World Health Organization. (2022). *Menstrual Health and Hygiene: An Issue of Human Rights and Public Health*.

The State of Menstrual Equity in Africa

Understanding the Scale of the Challenge, the Human Impact, and the Path Towards Change



3.1 Introduction: The African Menstrual Reality

Every month, millions of women and girls across Africa experience menstruation. Yet for many, a natural biological process is accompanied by barriers that affect their education, health, confidence, and participation in society.

Menstrual inequity remains one of the most overlooked challenges affecting women and girls across the continent.

The issue is not simply whether someone has a menstrual period. The issue is whether they have the ability to manage that period safely, privately, and with dignity.

Across Africa, menstrual experiences are shaped by multiple factors:

Poverty and Affordability

Access to Menstrual Products

Sanitation Infrastructure

Healthcare Availability

Education and Awareness

Cultural Beliefs and Stigma

Government Policies and Investment

With Africa home to one of the youngest populations in the world, addressing menstrual health is not only a health priority. It is an investment in education, gender equality, economic participation, and the future of communities.

3.2 Menstrual Equity in Numbers: Understanding the Scale

Menstrual health affects a significant proportion of Africa's population.

Women and girls of reproductive age represent hundreds of millions of people across the continent, meaning that menstrual health is not a niche issue. It is a major public health and development concern.

However, measuring menstrual equity remains challenging because many countries still lack comprehensive national data on menstrual health indicators. UNICEF notes that menstrual health data collection remains limited globally, with many countries lacking information on access to products, sanitation facilities, education, and participation barriers.

Despite these limitations, available evidence reveals significant inequalities.

Key Facts: Menstrual Health in Africa

Menstruation is experienced by millions every month

Every month, girls and women across Africa navigate menstrual cycles while balancing school, work, family responsibilities, and social expectations.

Yet many do so without:

Reliable access to menstrual products

Accurate information

Safe sanitation facilities

Supportive environments

Sanitation Remains a Major Barrier

Menstrual health requires more than menstrual products.

A girl needs:



Clean water



Private toilets



Soap



Safe disposal options



A place where she feels comfortable managing her period

UNICEF data shows that many adolescent girls globally still lack basic water, sanitation, and hygiene services, with a significant proportion living in sub-Saharan Africa.

In sub-Saharan Africa, school environments continue to present challenges:

1 in 10

Schools have bins for menstrual waste in girls' toilets

1 in 8

Schools provide menstrual materials free of charge or for purchase

These statistics represent more than infrastructure gaps.

They represent moments when girls must choose between managing their periods privately and participating fully in school.

3.3 Period Poverty: When Menstruation Becomes Unaffordable

One of the most visible forms of menstrual inequity in Africa is period poverty.

Period poverty occurs when individuals cannot access affordable menstrual products, sanitation facilities, education, or healthcare needed to manage menstruation safely.

For many families experiencing financial hardship, menstrual products compete with other essential needs:

Food

Transport

School Supplies

Medical Expenses

Household Bills

A monthly menstrual cycle becomes an additional financial burden.

This burden is often heavier for girls from low-income households, rural communities, and marginalised groups.

The impact extends beyond the cost of products.

When girls cannot afford menstrual materials, they may:

- stay home from school;
- use unsafe alternatives;
- experience anxiety about leakage;
- withdraw from activities.

UNICEF research has found that in some countries, girls report missing school because of their periods. For example, reported period-related school absence has affected girls in countries including **Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, and Nigeria.**

3.4 The Education Cost of Menstrual Inequity

Education is one of the areas most affected by menstrual inequality.

A girl's period should not determine whether she enters a classroom, participates in lessons, or reaches her academic potential.

However, menstrual barriers can affect school experiences through:

Absenteeism

**Reduced
Concentration**

Embarrassment

Fear of Teasing

Lack of Private Facilities

The issue is not menstruation itself.

The issue is whether schools are prepared to support menstruating students.

A menstrual-friendly school environment requires:

✓ **Accurate menstrual education**

✓ **Private toilets**

✓ **Water and soap**

✓ **Disposal facilities**

✓ **Supportive teachers**

✓ **Freedom from stigma**

UNICEF highlights that millions of girls lack access to appropriate menstrual health facilities in schools, creating barriers to safe and dignified menstrual management.

3.5 Beyond the Numbers: The Human Experience

Statistics tell us the scale of the problem.

Stories reveal the human impact.

Behind every percentage is a girl who may:

- Hide her period from classmates**
- Miss an important examination**
- Leave school early**
- Feel ashamed of a natural process**
- Grow up believing menstruation is something to conceal**

Menstrual inequity affects more than physical health.

It affects:

Confidence	Self-Esteem
Participation	Oppor tunity

This is why menstrual equity must be understood as an issue of dignity.

3.6 The Nigerian Context: A Closer Look

As Africa's most populous country, Nigeria represents a **critical case study** in understanding menstrual equity on the continent.

Millions of Nigerian girls and women experience menstruation within diverse realities ranging from urban centres to rural communities.

Challenges include:

Affordability of menstrual products

Inadequate school sanitation

Limited menstrual education

Cultural stigma

Unequal access between regions

A UNICEF assessment of menstrual hygiene management in Nigerian schools found that girls' experiences were influenced by access to materials, information, cultural beliefs, and the quality of school WASH facilities.

This highlights an important reality:

Menstrual inequality is not caused by one problem.

It is created by multiple systems failing at the same time.

3.7 African-Led Solutions: The Movement Towards Change

Although menstrual challenges remain significant, Africa is not defined only by inequality.

Across the continent, women, young people, communities, and organisations are creating solutions.

The future of menstrual equity will be shaped by African-led innovation.

A Thousand Women Africa: Empowering Girls Through Menstrual Equity

A Thousand Women Africa(ATW) approaches menstrual health as part of a broader mission of empowering women and girls through education, advocacy, and access.

Through its menstrual equity initiatives, ATW focuses on addressing period poverty while also challenging the silence and stigma surrounding menstruation.

The organisation's approach recognises that providing menstrual products is important, but lasting change requires:



Education



Awareness



**Community
Engagement**



Dignity



Sustainable Solutions

ATW's End Period Poverty Project reflects the belief that no girl should have her education interrupted because of a natural biological process.

The organisation's Buy One Give One model connects menstrual product access with social impact by allowing menstrual support to reach girls who need it most.

Luwa: Innovation for Sustainable Menstrual Solutions

The future of menstrual equity also requires innovation.

Luwa represents the growing movement towards sustainable menstrual solutions that consider both accessibility and environmental responsibility.

Sustainable menstrual products have the potential to:

- reduce long-term costs
- minimise environmental waste
- provide more choices for women and girls
- support locally relevant solutions

However, sustainability must always be combined with accessibility.

A solution is only effective when communities can access it, understand it, and use it comfortably.

3.8 The Way Forward

The State of Menstrual Equity in Africa reveals two realities:

The challenge is significant.

But the opportunity for change is equally significant.

Achieving menstrual equity requires:

- stronger government commitment
- better data collection
- investment in WASH infrastructure
- affordable menstrual products
- comprehensive education
- healthcare support
- African-led innovation

Menstrual equity is not only about periods.

It is about ensuring that every girl has the opportunity to learn, participate, work, and live with dignity.

3.9 Conclusion: Beyond the Statistics

The statistics presented throughout this chapter reveal a clear reality: menstrual inequity remains a significant challenge affecting millions of women and girls across Africa. Behind every percentage is a person whose education, health, confidence, and opportunities may be shaped by circumstances beyond their control.

Yet these statistics tell only part of the story.

Across the continent, women and girls continue to demonstrate remarkable resilience, while governments, civil society organisations, researchers, entrepreneurs, and communities are increasingly recognising menstrual health as a critical development priority. Progress is being made through policy reforms, improved education, local innovation, and advocacy, but significant gaps remain.

The evidence also highlights an important truth: menstrual inequity is not caused by menstruation itself. It is the result of systemic barriers, including poverty, inadequate sanitation, limited healthcare, persistent stigma, and insufficient investment. These barriers are preventable, and with coordinated action, they are solvable.

For Africa, investing in menstrual equity is not simply about providing menstrual products. It is about investing in girls' education, protecting women's health, advancing gender equality, strengthening economic participation, and upholding human dignity.

Organisations such as **A Thousand Women Africa** demonstrate how locally led initiatives can contribute to lasting change by combining menstrual product access with education, advocacy, community engagement, and sustainable solutions. Likewise, innovations such as Luwa reflect the growing potential for African-designed products and social enterprises to make menstrual care more accessible, affordable, and environmentally sustainable.

As Africa's youthful population continues to grow, the decisions made today will shape the experiences of future generations. Every school equipped with safe sanitation facilities, every community that challenges menstrual stigma, every government that invests in menstrual health, and every organisation that champions menstrual equity contributes to a future where no girl is excluded because of a natural biological process.

References

- African Union Commission. (2020). *African Union Strategy for Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment (2018–2028)*. Addis Ababa: African Union.
- Hennegan, J., Winkler, I. T., Bobel, C., Keiser, D., Hampton, J., Larsson, G., Chandra-Mouli, V., Plesons, M., & Mahon, T. (2021). *Menstrual health: A definition for policy, practice, and research*. *Sexual and Reproductive Health Matters*, 29(1), 1911618. *A girl's future should never be limited by a biological process she cannot control.*
- UNESCO. (2014). *Puberty Education and Menstrual Hygiene Management*. Paris: UNESCO.
- UNICEF. (2021). *Guidance on Menstrual Health and Hygiene*. New York: UNICEF.
- UNICEF & World Health Organization. (2024). *Progress on Drinking Water, Sanitation and Hygiene in Schools: Special Focus on Menstrual Health*. WHO/UNICEF Joint Monitoring Programme (JMP).
- UNICEF. (2024). *10 Fast Facts: Menstrual Health in Schools*. New York: UNICEF.
- UN Women. (2022). *The Impact of COVID-19 on Women and Girls*. New York: UN Women.
- United Nations. (2015). *Transforming Our World: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development*. New York: United Nations.
- WaterAid. (2022). *Menstrual Health Matters: Guidance and Good Practice for the Water, Sanitation and Hygiene Sector*. London: WaterAid.
- World Bank. (2018). *Menstrual Hygiene Management Enables Women and Girls to Reach Their Full Potential*. Washington, DC: World Bank.
- World Health Organization. (2022). *Statement on Menstrual Health and Hygiene*. Geneva: World Health Organization.



About A Thousand Women Africa

A Thousand Women Africa is a women-led organisation committed to advancing education, empowerment, and advocacy for women and girls across Africa. Through research, community programmes, policy engagement, and innovative solutions such as the End Period Poverty Project and Luwa (menstrual equity platform), the organisation works to ensure that every woman and girl can thrive with dignity, opportunity, and equitable access to essential resources.

MISSION

Empowered Women. Empower Generations.

WEBSITE

athousandwomenafrica.org

